TWELVE

July 1995

The second term of flight training was due to commence at the Helicopter Training School (HTS) in Hakimpet, Hyderabad. After a short break after our first term, we joined HTS in mid-July. I must mention here that HTS was entirely different from AFA in terms of training. There was no cadets' mess in HTS and we were put up in the officers' mess itself. At HTS, two cadets were asked to share a room and, as luck would have it, Anuradha and I were assigned the same room. We were elated, knowing we would get to spend two entire terms in each other's company. At HTS, we had senior cadets from the flying branch to guide us and tell us the tricks of the trade in order to survive the rigorous training sessions. Needless to say, it all came at the cost of ragda. The punishments had mellowed down quite a lot, but it was mostly because we had now learnt to avoid punishments.

Physical training was little emphasized as compared to flying and academics, where our focus had to lie. Except for PT and drill periods in the morning and afternoon, the rest of our schedule was similar to the one in AFA, with morning and afternoon flying sessions scheduled on alternate weeks. No study period was observed in the evening in HTS, but the extensive subject syllabus would compel us to study on our own. It all started with a mechanical conversion helicopter course, which went on for